encounter. To do that effectively, it is absolutely vital to develop an accurate and updated understanding of what the world is really about. And today, our existence is shaped by a set of trends and happenings whose externality does not in any way mitigate their deep domestic relevance.

Any objective global assessment now has to recognize the prospect of uninhibited competition among nations, especially the major ones. What that essentially means is that they have not only developed many more capabilities and influence but are also more inclined to exercise them. It is expressed through visible linking of sectors that were generally regarded as autonomous. Business, energy and finance are treated as intrinsic to strategy, as are sports, tourism, education and politics. Norms and firewalls have fallen by the wayside in that process, as have assumptions of what is fair or acceptable. Some of this transformation is structural, but it is strengthened by changes that are behavioural. Globalization and technology would reflect the former; nationalism and unilateralism the latter. The world has seen a sharp increase in risk-taking propensities. No country can remain uninvolved or unaffected, and India is no exception. The bottom line is that our external environment is now much more hazardous.

But the home front is no less challenged, since the phenomenon of borderless politics has erased that comfort too. Many of the same forces also contribute to it, but the variables stack up differently. The ability and the inclination to pronounce on, influence and direct developments in other societies are clearly on the rise. Like established globalization, borderless politics is also played to the benefit of a few. But as in that case, it also shares the advantage of being marketed as in the interest of many. Its expressions range across every medium of opinion formulation and image shaping. Through shaping narratives and argumentation, it seeks to both legitimize and de-legitimize. This may be a broader phenomenon, but that should not obfuscate its security implications. After all, it can disenchant or disturb, or on occasion, incite and encourage challenges. Indeed, motivating beliefs are often backed by a flow of accompanying resources to make them more actionable. It is, therefore, a naïve polity that does not monitor external transactions and when required, regulate them.

Significantly, Western nations are as active as non-democratic ones in this respect, whether legislatively, through intelligence or by administrative action. When India is sometimes targeted on that score, the irony is that such criticism often comes from those with more stringent monitoring